

grain worth Re 1 to a person living below poverty line.

The crux of the matter is that departments and ministries are created not on economic or administrative logic but political arithmetic. "The multiplicity of ministries creates layers and nothing is quite delivered," says Bimal Jalan, MP and former governor of the Reserve Bank of India. As Jalan points out, such is the multi-layering that if one wants to improve sports facilities for women in rural areas it is not one but seven ministries (Rural Development, Social Justice, Sports, Youth Affairs, Finance, Women and Child Welfare and Panchayati Raj besides the Planning Commission) who will be involved. In a seminal paper on administrative reforms, S.R. Maheshwari says, "The number of departments in the Government of India grew from three (Public, Secret, and Revenue) in 1774 to eight in 1833. It then expanded to 10 in 1919 and 18 in 1947. No other country has such a large retinue of ministers."

Arun Shourie, BJP MP and former minister, says, "Accommodation of politicians leads to accumulation of babus." In 1948, the number of secretaries to the Government of India was 19 and that of IAS officers 143. The expansion has also imposed a huge cost—as high as 2 per cent in terms of GDP growth—on the economy. Today there are 134 IAS officers just at secretary-level postings, while the number of IAS officers posted in the

Central Government is 820. First there is a directorate, then it is upgraded to a department and then to a ministry. And even after the ministry is disbanded—like in the case of disinvestment—the department stays.

True. In a developing economy there are new areas that require government attention. C. Rangarajan, chairman of the Prime Minister's Economic Advisory Council and former governor of RBI, points out, "There is a need to create new focus areas and retire old positions which have lost relevance." As he says: "If there is a sunrise sector, there should also be sunsets." But that hasn't been the case with India. It is not that the problem has not been studied or discussed. Between 1947 and 2007, no less than 30 committees and commissions have studied the issue. In fact the Administrative Reforms Commission (ARC) of 1966 had clearly advocated smaller governments. Neither that nor any other report was implemented, and as with the church, sin and evangelism continue to co-exist.

By allowing the multi-layered system to continue, political parties face not just a collapse of governance but also their own future. As India turns 60, it is time for some ministries to be retired, the concept of minister of state buried and funding of line ministries critical to social development relocated to the states. In 1947 we made our tryst with destiny. It's time we made a tryst with the future.

**THE NUMBER
OF MINISTRIES
HAS SHOT UP
FROM A MERE
18 IN 1947 TO
53 IN 2004.**

Drought of Ideas

MINISTRY OF AGRICULTURE

Staff: 11,711

Wages and allowances: Rs 191.25 crore

Total plan and non-plan expenditure: Rs 9,362.21 crore

RATIONALE: To formulate and implement national policies and programmes aimed at achieving agricultural growth through optimum utilisation of land, water and plant resources; formulate overall cooperative policy, oversee research and maintain statistics.

REALITY CHECK: Production of grains and pulses is stagnant for over a decade, productivity is down, almost 20,000 farmers commit suicide every year. There has been no breakthrough in seeds or yield since the Green Revolution and agriculture is unviable. The Centre's defence is that the problem lies with the states. Indeed everything under agriculture—agricultural education and research, protection against pests,

prevention of plant diseases and improvement of cattle stock—is listed as a state subject in the Seventh Schedule of the Constitution. So what is the big idea of hosting an army of people in Krishi Bhavan?

Agriculture, which is India's largest private sector enterprise, supports 56 per cent of the working population while delivering 19 per cent of the GDP.

Too many people are dependent on a crashing enterprise. The Indian farmer is growing less on a shrinking holding, spending more for inputs for an income that is not only falling but has to be shared with a growing number of dependents. Yet there has been no attempt to restructure the sector. India needs to go in for manpower-intensive, value-added crops. Post-land reforms, with land holdings at less than two hectare per capita, it cannot adopt scale-neutral methods. The situation calls for drastic action, not the usual mix of incrementalism and pious sermons. Yet the focus is on more committees. At least six committees have studied credit to farmers, four have studied use of genetically modified seeds, three have studied investment in irrigation, but there has been no action on the ground. But that has not prevented every minister from expanding the ministry. Established in 1871, the ministry has gone through 48 avatars. It deserves *moksha*.

